Foundation Day by planting a ‘new party flag’ at their residence, ensuring that they maintained ‘social distancing while hoisting’, and provide food packets to the needy, as well as two home-made masks to ‘each person in our booth’. Seamlessly merging the impulses of routine political mobilisation with the imperatives of a national health emergency, Nadda’s directive told party workers that ‘since BJP will be celebrating its 40th Foundation Day’, they should get forty others to donate to the PM Cares Fund and also contact ‘forty houses in your booth’ and get their signatures on five thank-you letters for police, doctors, safai karamcharis, and bank, postal and government employees.[3]

The voting booth has been at the heart of the BJP’s organisational growth efforts since 2014. The party’s decision not to forgo its anniversary celebrations and to adapt its voting-booth mobilisation plans for outreach work even during the lockdown reflected how important ‘sangathan’ work was to the leadership.

A few minutes later, Vinay Sahasrabuddhe tweeted again—this time with photos of himself in a mask, distributing food to local workers: ‘In observance of @BJP4India’s Sthapna Divas [Foundation Day], remained on fast and distributed home cooked food to few Sanitation and Maintenance Labourers in our residential area, while insisting that they must use masks and take care of hand washing regularly!’[4]

How the BJP Became Larger than the Chinese Communist Party and the RSS

The BJP’s cadre growth and membership numbers have not elicited adequate attention outside party circles.[5] This is because the BJP and the RSS have long had a symbiotic relationship, and the RSS’s cadre network—which has been the focus of relatively more scholarly and journalistic attention—often helps the BJP in elections. However, the party is distinct from the RSS. While Sangh cadres have always been sympathetic to the BJP, they were never the BJP’s own cadres. (A senior RSS leader once famously asked, ‘Which other party is there in the country [for us to support], Sonia